As China's economy began to unravel openly during 2015 and the US equity markets precipitously declined in early 2016, Japan is a country neither sprinting ahead nor rocked by economic instability. The uncertainty that clouds so many of the world's economies exacts psychic and material costs, but Japan, where GDP growth has been sluggish for decades, seems less threatened by the roller coaster that is prevalent in the West, in part because its system remains more resistant to radical restructuring and the diktats of unrestrained market forces. In fact, things simply aren't all that bad.

Japan remains a high-income country by Organization for Economic Cooperation and Development (OECD) standards. Its GDP per capita at purchasing-power parity rates increased from $35,779 in 2011 to $42,823 in 2018, while the cost of living in Tokyo and other major cities declined, due in part to moderate deflationary trends.[9] Japan's Gini coefficient, which measures income inequality, stood at .32 in 2008 (the latest year available), according to the World Bank. Though higher than many European nations, it likely remains lower than America's 2013 measure of .41, indicating a more equal society.

Economic data tell only part of the national story. Other measures show a picture of social strength. To give just a few examples, Americans are fifteen times as likely to be murdered as their Japanese counterparts, according to the United Nations.[10] Japan, with approximately 40 percent of the population of the United States, recorded just 442 cases of intentional homicide in 2011, a rate of 0.3 per 100,000 inhabitants. Meanwhile in America, 14,661 persons were murdered intentionally, a rate of 4.7 per 100,000. While gun control advocates point out that Japan has far more stringent gun laws than the United States, crimes of all kinds, especially violent crimes, occur far less frequently in Japan than in America. Japan is a more peaceful society because of factors other than regulation of guns. There is less overall poverty, fewer impoverished inner city areas, and different segments of society rarely seem to see each other as threats or have contentious relations.

Japan remains a male-dominated society, and sexism is a pervasive problem, yet Japanese women also are among the most highly educated